Fieldwork Tradition in Anthropology

Research methods in anthropology: (a) fieldwork tradition in anthropology — from the armchair to the avatar

12 PYQs 1998–2026
+ 8 in 1981–89 · one in each of 2024, 2025, 2026 · history to 2018, "fieldwork now" since 2020 · Mains Value **High**

THE ANSWER SPINE ① Armchair → ② Expedition → ③ Malinowski and the classics → ④ Critique → ⑤ Remade: new forms, ethics

① DEFINITIONS · ARMCHAIR · EXPEDITION

1998 · 2011 · 2014 2016 · 2018

Fieldwork: first-hand, long-term research living with a community. **Ethnography:** the **process** (fieldwork) and the **product** (the written account). **Ethnology** compares.

HOOK *Asked if he had ever met the "savages" he wrote about, Frazer is said to have replied "God forbid!" (anecdote).*

Armchair (to c. 1890): Tylor 1871 · Frazer, *Golden Bough* 1890 · *Notes and Queries* 1874 — questions for amateurs · Morgan with Ely Parker, Iroquois 1851. **Weak: second-hand data.**

HOOK *Boas's doctorate was on the colour of seawater; a winter with the Inuit (1883–84) made him an anthropologist.*

Expedition (1883–1910s): Boas — Baffin Island 1883, Kwakiutl 1886 with George Hunt; salvage ethnography · **Torres Strait 1898** — Haddon, Rivers, Seligman · **Rivers** — genealogical method 1910, "intensive work" 1913 · Radcliffe-Brown, Andamans 1906–08. **Weak: short stays, interpreters.**

② CHARACTERISTICS · FIELDWORK → THEORY

2017 · 15M 1999 · 2008

#	Characteristic	#	Characteristic
1	long residence — an annual cycle	6	rapport, key informants
2	participant observation	7	several tools, triangulated
3	the local language	8	inductive, qualitative
4	holism	9	small scale, intensive
5	emic checked by etic	10	reflexivity and ethics

Fieldwork made theory (1999): functionalism ← Trobriands · segmentary lineage ← Nuer · historical particularism ← Boas · dominant caste, Sanskritisation ← Coorg and Rampura · culture and personality ← Samoa · and unmade it: Leach's Kachin oscillation (1954).

HOOK *1951–52: S. C. Dube's team in Shamirpet, near Hyderabad — Indian Village (1955), one of the first whole-village studies by an Indian.*

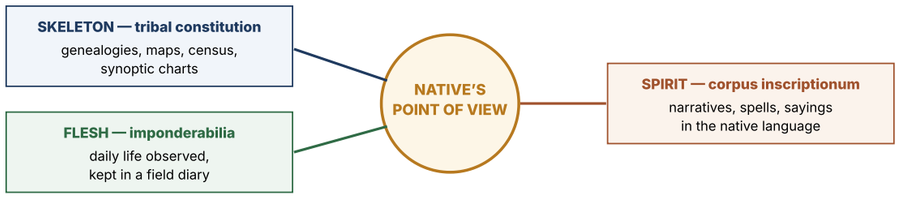
India: Risley 1901, Thurston 1909 (colonial survey) · **S. C. Roy**, Mundas 1912, Oraons 1915 · Elwin, Baiga 1939 · Haimendorf — Chenchus, Raj Gonds, Apatanis · Srinivas, Rampura · Marriott 1955 · AnSI 1945; People of India 1985–92.

Basis	Classical	Contemporary
Field	a bounded village	networks, sites, screens, species
Researcher	lone Western outsider	native, team, collaborator
Authority	"I was there"	reflexive, dialogic
First duty	to science	to the people studied

★ HERO — FIVE PHASES, FROM THE VERANDAH TO THE NETWORK

draw for any history stem

1 Armchair to 1890	2 Expedition 1883–1910s	3 Malinowski 1915–60s	4 Critique 1967–90	5 Remade 1990s →
Tylor · Frazer · *Notes & Queries* 1874 **untested data**	Boas · Torres Strait 1898 · Rivers **short stays**	Trobriands · E-P, Firth, Mead · Roy, Srinivas, Dube **the lone hero**	Diary 1967 · Asad 1973 · Nader 1972 · Freeman 1983 · *Writing Culture* 1986	multi-sited · digital · multispecies · critical · ethics



Malinowski, *Argonauts* 1922 — three principles: scientific aims · live among the people · special methods of collection

③ MALINOWSKI AND THE CLASSICAL AGE

every history answer

HOOK *1914: an Austro-Hungarian subject in wartime Australia, Malinowski was allowed to keep researching — and spent 1915–18 in a tent in the Trobriands.*

Classical monographs: Radcliffe-Brown, *Andaman Islanders* 1922 · Mead, *Coming of Age in Samoa* 1928 · Firth, *We, the Tikopia* 1936 · Evans-Pritchard, Azande 1937, *The Nuer* 1940 · Fortes, Tallensi. One people, one place, the "ethnographic present", holistic, theory-led.

HOOK *1967: Malinowski's private diary — lonely, irritable, contemptuous — punctures the myth of the serene observer.*

Basis	Boas	Malinowski
Field	repeated visits	continuous residence
Data	native texts, collaborators	participant observation, diary
Aim	history of particular cultures	how institutions work now

✎ EXAM OPENERS — HOOKS YOU CAN WRITE

first two lines

- **History:** "A wartime accident made a method: Malinowski's Trobriand years (1915–18) ended the age of the armchair."
- **Characteristics:** "Fieldwork is to anthropology what the laboratory is to chemistry — the place where its knowledge is made."
- **Challenges:** "The field is no longer a village reached by boat but a network, a city, a screen — and the studied now read back."
- **Ethics:** "Project Camelot (1965) taught anthropologists that who pays for fieldwork, and why, is an ethical question."

④ CRITIQUE AND NEW FORMS

2020 · 2025 notes

HOOK *Mead, 23, found carefree Samoan adolescence (1928); Freeman (1983) said her informants had been joking — still disputed.*

Critiques: Diary 1967 · **Asad**, *Colonial Encounter* 1973 · **Nader** 1972 "study up" · Freeman 1983 · *Writing Culture* 1986 · native, feminist, "halfie" (Abu-Lughod 1991) anthropologists.

HOOK *Anna Tsing followed the matsutake mushroom from Oregon to Japan — people, fungi and pines all actors (2015).*

Form	Who
multi-sited — follow the thing, person, conflict	Marcus 1995
multispecies — non-humans as participants	Kirksey & Helmreich 2010; Tsing
critical — fieldwork against injustice	Thomas 1993; Madison 2005
experiential — the body and feeling as data	Rosaldo 1989; Stoller 1989
digital — online worlds	Boellstorff 2008
collaborative · auto-ethnography	Lassiter 2005; Reed-Danahay 1997

⑤ CHALLENGES AND ETHICS

2024 · 15M 2026 · 10M

Challenges → responses: access and gatekeeping → negotiation · consent with vulnerable groups → oral, ongoing consent · positionality → reflexivity, teams · safety → remote methods · the unbounded field → multi-sited, digital · time and money → **patchwork ethnography** (Günel, Varma & Watanabe 2020) · communities read back → sharing, co-authorship · data protection → anonymisation.

HOOK *1965: the US Army's Project Camelot, an insurgency study planned for Chile, was exposed and cancelled — and anthropologists wrote their first ethics statements.*

AAA: 1967 statement · 1971 Principles · Codes 1998, 2009 · 2012 Statement. **Principles:** do no harm · informed consent · openness on funding · confidentiality · first duty to the people studied · benefit-sharing. **Cases:** Thailand 1970 · Yanomami / *Darkness in El Dorado* 2000 · Human Terrain System 2007. **India:** PVTG consent; sacred knowledge; ICMR 2017.

Basis	Armchair	Field
Data	second-hand reports	first-hand observation
Scope	world-wide comparison	one community in depth
Theory	evolutionary stages	function, structure, meaning

Traps: ethnography ≠ ethnology · Rivers came before Malinowski · Mead–Freeman is disputed · Frazer's line is an anecdote.

THE VERDICT TO WRITE Each phase answered the weakness of the one before — the armchair lacked **data**, the expedition **depth**, the lone fieldworker **reflexivity**. The critiques did not abolish fieldwork; they changed **who studies whom, where the field is, how it is written, and what is owed to the people studied**. Long residence, language and participant observation endure — knowledge earned by being there, now under ethics.